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IMPACT OF SOCIAL MEDIA INFLUENCER MARKETING ON PURCHASE INTENTION OF GEN Z CONSUMERS

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ABSTRACT:

Social media influencer marketing has become an effective promotional strategy among Generation Z, who increasingly rely on platforms such as Instagram, YouTube, and TikTok for product recommendations and purchasing decisions. This study examines the impact of influencer marketing on Gen Z's purchase intention in India, focusing on trust, content authenticity, and audience engagement. Data were collected through a questionnaire with over 30 valid responses and interviews with two professional Instagram influencers. The findings indicate that trust, authentic content, honest product representation, visual quality, and social proof influence purchase intention. However, excessive promotions can reduce trust, while price sensitivity affects final buying decisions. The study highlights the importance of authenticity, transparency, and understanding consumer preferences for successful influencer marketing.

Keywords: • *Influencer Marketing* • *Gen Z* • *Purchase Intention* • *Social Media* • *Consumer Trust* • *Digital Marketing* • *Content Authenticity* • *Instagram*

INTRODUCTION

Over the past 10 years, the progress of technology around digital communication has altered nearly every factor of human commercial activity. In marketing, the effects of these advances have been both vast and permanent. The traditional "advertising" medium of TV, print, radio, and outdoor billboards are becoming far less relevant than their digital-native counterparts, which can reach more precisely targeted consumers in real-time and with demonstrably higher levels of engagement. Social media like Instagram, YouTube, TikTok, Twitter, and Snapchat have transitioned from previously serving as auxiliary communication methods to being the primary channels that brands will use to create awareness, encourage loyalty, and stimulate purchase. According to Voorveld (2019), social media brand communication is different from conventional advertising in that it encourages participation rather than just being a one-way channel from sender to receiver; thus, the consumer, as an example, can be a brand's audience, reviewer, and amplifier all at the same time.

With the pace of development of modern digital communications, influencer marketing has quickly emerged as a separate and high-impact form of social media marketing. Influencer marketing consists of brands partnering with people who have amassed credibility, expertise, or loyalty from their audiences on digital platforms to provide endorsements or recommendations for their products and/or services in a manner that feels personal and relatable rather than "commercial." Previous decades saw celebrity endorsements that were heavily reliant on aspiration and mass visibility. In the era of influencer marketing, these endorsements are instead based on intimacy, trust, and perceived authenticity as peers. This means rather than being distant cultural icons, influencers are followed because they are "knowable" and "real," suggesting products much the same way that an informed friend would (Campbell & Farrell, 2020). validate those decisions socially, and often complete purchases entirely within the same digital ecosystem (Arora et al., 2023). Brands that want to attract and develop brand loyalty with Gen Z should consider implementing influencer marketing. As a standalone tactic, influencer marketing provides brands with another avenue to reach potential customers; however, as the industry's projected size indicates ($21+ billion by 2023), there are still significant questions regarding the specific mechanisms by which influencer marketing works on the behavior of consumers in general.

These additional mediating factors include the perceived trustworthiness of the influencer, the quality of the influencer's content (e.g., video vs. photo), the environment in which the influencer's content is shared on social media (e.g., on Facebook, Instagram, or Twitter), the degree of transparency about whether or not the influencer was compensated for promoting the brand; and the fit and relationship between the influencer and their audience. Brands can undermine the vice of influencer's persuasive future order as true endorsements by

using an influencer to over-promote their brand, writing commercial scripts for said influencers to use in their promotion, and/or creating fake endorsements by paying for influencers to create fake endorsements for the brand (Lou et al. 2020).

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

The research surrounding influencer marketing is an interdisciplinary blend of consumer psychology, digital communication, and marketing strategy. Given its growth and maturation over recent years, there is now a significant, growing, and increasingly comprehensive body of literature to help us understand how and why influencer marketing works as well as in what contexts it impacts consumer behaviour. This literature review synthesizes the most current and relevant research across four thematic domains: the nature and evolution of influencer marketing as a discipline; the role of trust and credibility in digital persuasion; the construct of purchase intention and its determinants in the influencer context; and the distinctive behavioral and psychological characteristics of Generation Z as a consumer group.

2.1 Influencer Marketing: Nature, Evolution, and Strategic Significance

Influencer marketing as a formal discipline has its conceptual roots in earlier theories of opinion leadership and word-of-mouth communication. The concept of influence on a large scale based on an individual's social context through an expert position, trustworthy source, or celebrity status has been around long before social media. However, the digital age has amplified that effect exponentially by democratizing this model and giving individuals the ability to create an audience, which can dwarf traditional celebrity audiences, and monetize them through brand relationships and sponsorships (Hudders et al., 2021).

Influencers are generally divided into categories based on the size of their audiences; these include nano-influencers (fewer than 10,000 followers), micro-influencers (between 10,000 and 100,000), macro-influencers (between 100,000 and 1 million), and mega-influencers (over 1 million). These categories all provide advantages and disadvantages. Mega-influencers have a significantly larger reach but typically have lower engagement rates and less authenticity than micro/nano-influencers, who most often enjoy the highest engagement rates, trust from their communities, and relevance to specific niches (Vrontis et al., 2021). Recent research indicates that these last two categories provide brands with the highest return on investment with respect to genuine behaviours, such as intent to purchase and conversion, compared to traditional advertising methods, which primarily provide brands with exposure through impressions.

From a strategic standpoint, influencer marketing has also changed dramatically as brands progress regarding their partnership model. Historically, brands entered into influencer partnerships on transactional lines—brands paid for posts and influencers created and posted content, ending their relationship after payment.

2.2 Trust and Credibility in the Digital Influencer Context

Trust is widely recognized in the marketing literature as a foundational prerequisite for consumer engagement and purchasing behavior. In digital environments, where face-to-face interaction is absent and the line between authentic and commercially motivated communication is frequently blurred, trust is both more difficult to establish and more consequential when lost. For influencer marketing specifically, trust serves as the primary conduit through which content exposure translates into attitudinal change and behavioral intention. Without trust, even high-quality, visually compelling influencer content is unlikely to move consumers toward purchase consideration (Ismagilova et al., 2020). The classical source credibility model, originally developed in the context of mass communication, identifies expertise and trustworthiness as the two core dimensions of credibility that determine how persuasively a message is received. Recent studies have investigated how different types of content and disclosure practices affect trust. Lou et al. (2022) found that the manner in which sponsored content is disclosed significantly moderates its persuasive impact. Transparent, clearly labeled disclosures that are integrated naturally into the influencer's narrative voice tend to preserve trust, while disclosures that feel like legal boilerplate or are buried in hashtags generate suspicion and reduce content effectiveness.

2.3 Purchase Intention and Its Determinants in the Influencer Marketing Context

Purchase intention refers to the degree to which a consumer is predisposed to acquire a specific product or service, and it is widely regarded as the most proximate behavioral antecedent to actual purchase. In marketing research, purchase intention is both an output variable that represents the cumulative impacts of exposure to, attitude formation about and motivation to act on a given marketing communication, as well as a predictor of actual purchase behaviour. Understanding the elements that shape purchase intention is particularly important in the context of influencer marketing as they reveal how exposure to content creates commercial value for brands. An increasing number of studies have explored the specific mechanisms that link exposure to influencer content with higher levels of purchase intention. For example, Han and Chen (2023) showed that the informational value of influencer content (i.e., its ability to provide consumers with information about the features, benefits and correct use of products) is a robust and separate predictor of purchase intention over and above the general trustworthiness of the influencer. This means that influencer-generated content that blends

relational authenticity with meaningful product knowledge is more contextually relevant to brand brands than influencer-generated content in which one dimension is prioritised over the other. Consequently, when briefing for influencer partnerships, brands should ensure that influencers receive true product information rather than pre-scripted talking points. In addition to the above, emotional connections to influencer content have also been shown to have a documented impact on shaping purchase intention. Influencers have used the idea of parasocial interaction (the ability of a viewer to form a one sided emotional bond/connection with a person they often view via their media) to great advantage in marketing. Breves et al. (2021) found that consumers who have developed strong parasocial bonds with an influencer show significantly higher purchase intention when that influencer recommends a product, compared to consumers with weaker parasocial attachments.

3. RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This chapter outlines the methodological framework employed to investigate the effect of social media influencer marketing on the purchase intention of Gen Z consumers. It covers the research design, data collection approach, sampling strategy, analytical tools, conceptual model, and the hypotheses formulated to guide the study.

3.1 Research Design

This study follows a descriptive and analytical research design, integrating both quantitative and qualitative methodological approaches within a mixed-methods framework. In this study, the descriptive dimension enables researchers to systematically describe how regularly and for what purpose Gen Z consumers use social media, their attitudes towards influencer content, and how they react to influencer marketing stimulus. From this perspective, researchers can map the boundaries of consumer behaviour among a defined segment of the Gen Z population while being careful not to manipulate or control any of the variables under investigation.

On the other hand, The use of a mixed-methods methodology is optimally suited to the objectives of this study. Quantitative data will be collected using a structured survey that will provide the statistical basis for making generalised claims on the behaviours and attitudes of the Gen Z respondent. Qualitative data will be obtained from semi-structured interviews with practising influencers to provide researchers with additional context, background and experiential detail that the quantitative data cannot provide. Creswell and Creswell (2023) argue that mixed-methods designs are particularly appropriate for studies in which a phenomenon is complex, context-dependent, and not fully explained by any single methodological tradition a characterization that applies directly to the dynamics of influencer marketing and consumer behavior**.**

3.2 Data Collection

The study employs both primary and secondary data collection methods. We used a structured questionnaire to collect information about demographics, and people's views and actions toward social media influencer advertisements. The questionnaire was sent out to a group of digitally connected Gen Z respondents. We received a total of 34 completed surveys from Gen Z respondents, which we used for quantitative analysis.

Primary Data

I collected primary qualitative data through interviews with two current Instagram influencers to gain information about their experiences in creating content, working with brands, building trust with audiences and understanding their followers' purchase behaviour. Interviewing semi-structure allows me to maintain a similar theme throughout all of my interviews while being able to explore and talk about topics that come out of the conversations.

Secondary Data

The secondary data that I used for this study were peer-reviewed journal articles, conference papers, and respectable online digital marketing articles. This provided me with the theoretical brownstone you're looking for, the contextual background to ground you in terms of how to understand and interpret your data, and the comparative benchmarks you need in order to compare your results with prior research.

3.3 Sample

The target population for this study is Gen Z consumers, operationalized as individuals between the ages of 18 and 25, who are active users of social media platforms and have had meaningful exposure to influencer content. This age range was selected because it captures the segment of Gen Z with the greatest purchasing autonomy, the most developed consumption habits, and the highest level of engagement with influencer content across the platforms most relevant to this study. The 32 responses collected are sufficient for the descriptive analysis undertaken in this study and provide a meaningful initial evidence base for the claims advanced.

3.4 Tools Used for Analysis

The study primarily utilizes **descriptive statistical tools** for analyzing the collected data. The responses obtained through Google Forms were processed using:

- **Microsoft Excel**
- **Google Forms built-in analytics**

Various types of charts and graphs were used to visually represent the data, including:

- Pie charts (for demographic distribution)
- Bar graphs (for Likert-scale responses)

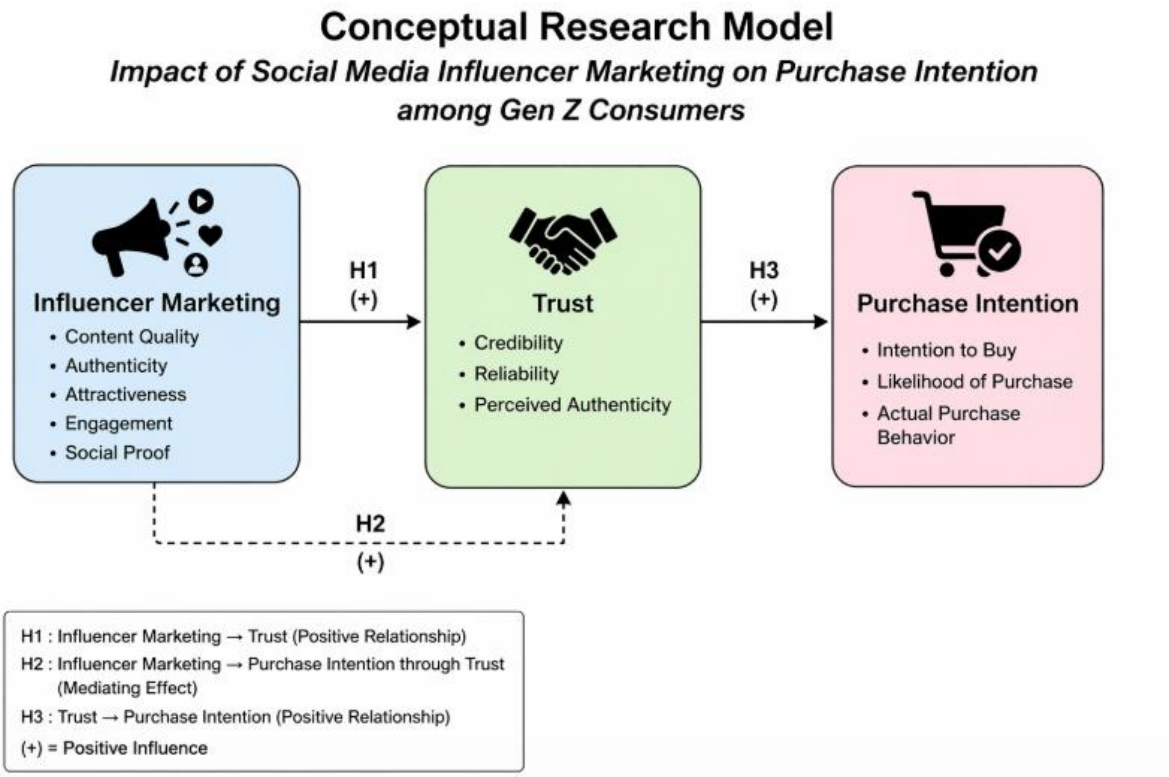
Graphical representations of data are useful for simplifying complex data sets and aiding in making sense of the data. As Field (2018) points out, presenting data graphically makes it easier to analyze the data and understand the results of a study. Quantitative data were analyzed with Microsoft Excel and the analytics tools found in Google Forms. The quantitative data were organized, cleaned, and summarized using frequency tables and percentage calculation before the results were displayed in pie charts and bar graphs to help the reader to quickly understand the results. In research like this, displaying survey data graphically can help the reader to quickly identify distributional patterns, understand the majority when there is one, and determine how opinions are distributed among the Likert scale categories without having to look at the raw numbers.

3.5 Research Model

The conceptual model guiding this study posits social media influencer marketing as the independent variable and identifies three dependent variables: consumer trust, trust tendency, and purchase intention. The model proposes that exposure to influencer marketing content directly and positively affects consumers' levels of trust in the influencers they follow, that this trust builds a broader tendency toward trusting influencer-mediated information more generally, and that both trust and trust tendency contribute to elevated purchase intention. This framework is grounded in source credibility theory and the extended electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM) literature, both of which identify perceived credibility and trust as critical mediating mechanisms in the relationship between digital marketing communication and behavioral response.. The model consists of:

- **Independent Variable:** Social Media Influencer Marketing
- **Dependent Variables:**
    - Trust
    - Trust Tendency
    - Purchase Intention

The model is based on the assumption that consumer trust and trust tendency are directly affected by influencer marketing, which leads to an increase in purchase intention. The importance of trust as a mediating variable in the effectiveness of digital marketing is supported by past research (Lou and Yuan, 2019).



3.6 Hypotheses

Based on the objectives of the research and the conceptual framework, the hypotheses are as follows:

- H1: Influencer marketing via social media is a major positive factor that affects consumer trust among Gen Z.
- H2: Social media influencer marketing positively affects trust tendency of Gen Z consumers significantly.
- H3: The purchase intention of Gen Z consumers is strongly positively influenced by social media influencer marketing.

These are the hypotheses that are subject to descriptive analysis and confirmed by the quantitative results and the qualitative information.

4. DATA ANALYSIS & INTERPRETATION

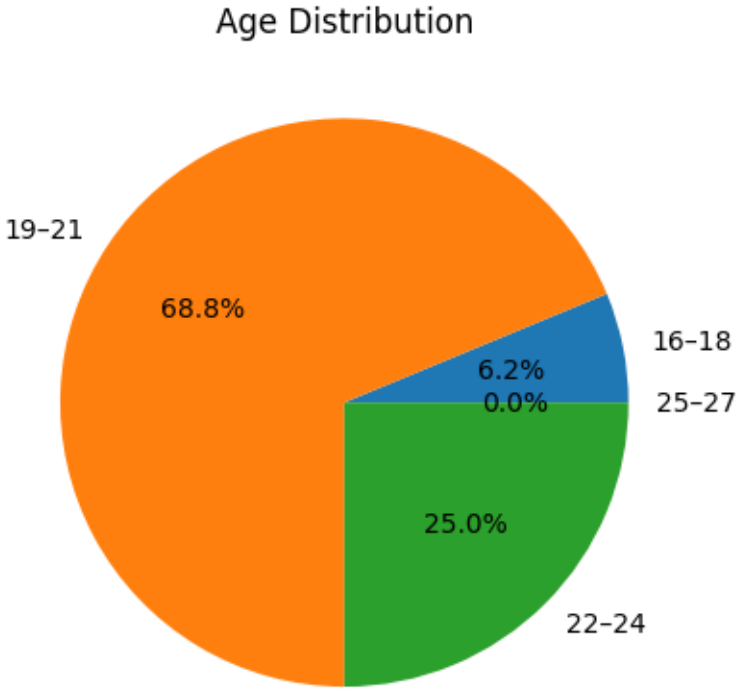
In this section, it is possible to find the analysis of primary data on 32 respondents of Gen Z. Descriptive statistics have been used to analyze the data and it has been represented in the form of charts to make it easier to understand. All the variables are understood to assess the effects of influencer marketing on consumer behaviour.

4.1 Demographic Analysis

4.1.1 Age Distribution

Table 4.1: Age Group of Respondents

Age Group	No. of Respondents	Percentage
16–18	2	6.2%
19–21	22	68.8%
22–24	8	25%
25–27	0	0%
Total	**32**	**100%**

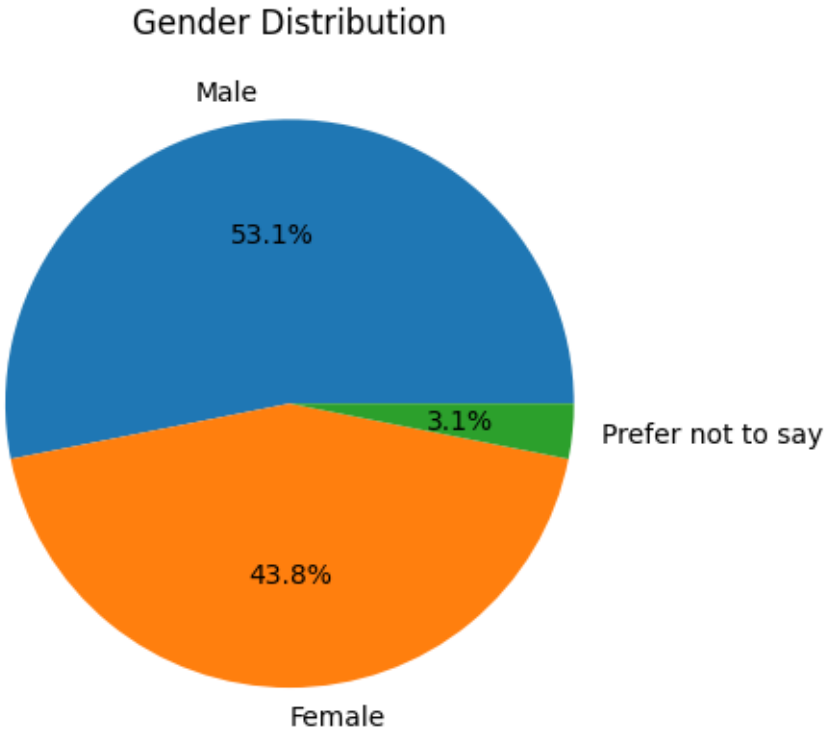


Interpretation: Most respondents (68.8) are aged between 19 and 21, which means that the research mainly represents the behavior of core Gen Z consumers. This category is more active and exposed to the content of influencers on social media, so the data is highly relevant to this study.

4.1.2 Gender Distribution

Table 4.2: Gender of Respondents

Gender	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Male	17	53.1%
Female	14	43.8%
Prefer not to say	1	3.1%
Total	**32**	**100%**



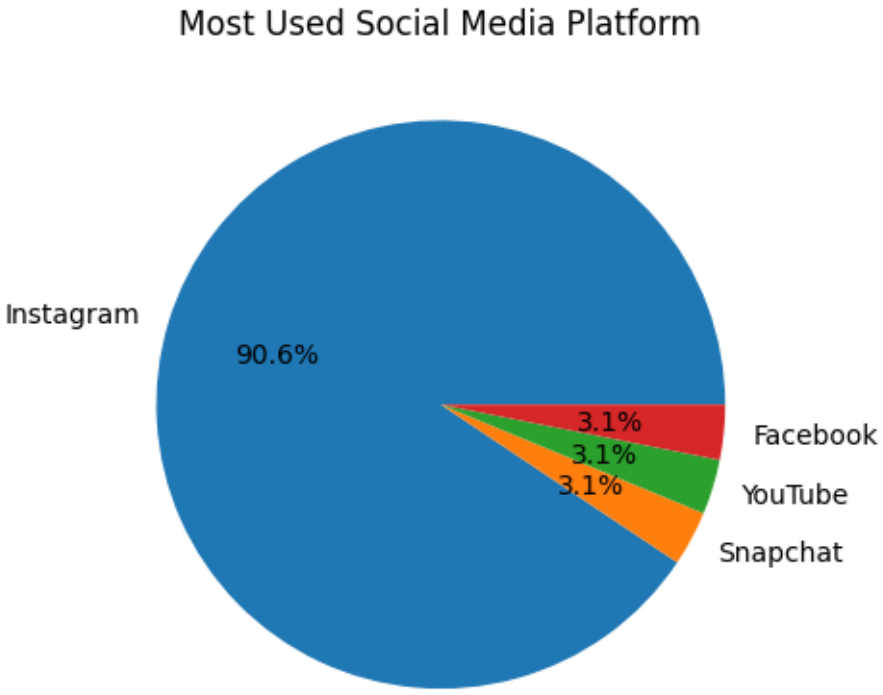
Interpretation: The sample reflects the equal representation of male (53.1) and female (43.8) respondents. This will make sure that the results are not skewed to a particular gender and represent Gen Z behavior, in general.

4.2 Social Media Platform Usage

Table 4.3: Most Used Social Media Platform

Platform	Responses	Percentage
Instagram	29	90.6%

Snapchat	1	3.1%
YouTube	1	3.1%
Facebook	1	3.1%
Total	**32**	**100%**



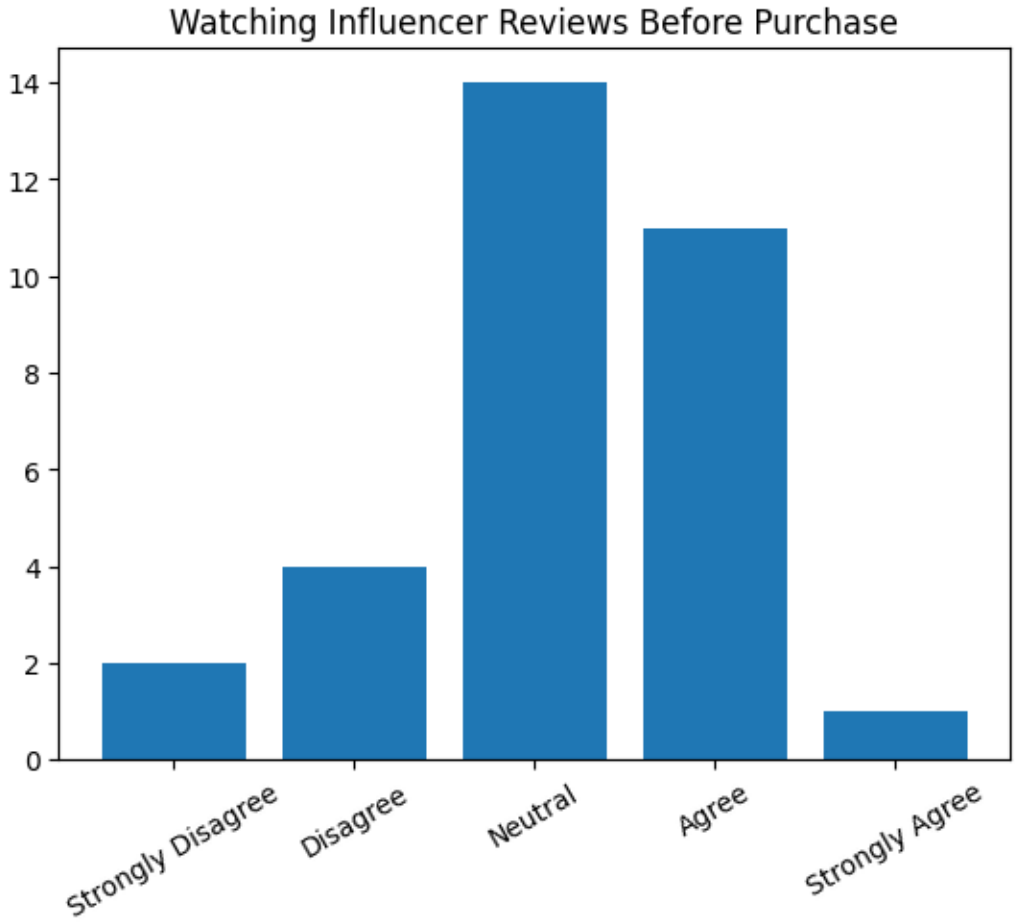
Interpretation: Instagram is the leading platform (90.6%), which speaks of its relevance in the influencer marketing strategies. This means that brands that aim at Gen Z ought to consider campaigns based on Instagram.

4.3 Influence of Influencer Reviews Before Purchase

Table 4.4: Watching Influencer Reviews Before Purchase

Response	No. of Responses	Percentage
Strongly Disagree	2	6.3%
Disagree	4	12.5%
Neutral	14	43.8%

Agree	11	34.4%
Strongly Agree	1	3.1%
Total	**32**	**100%**



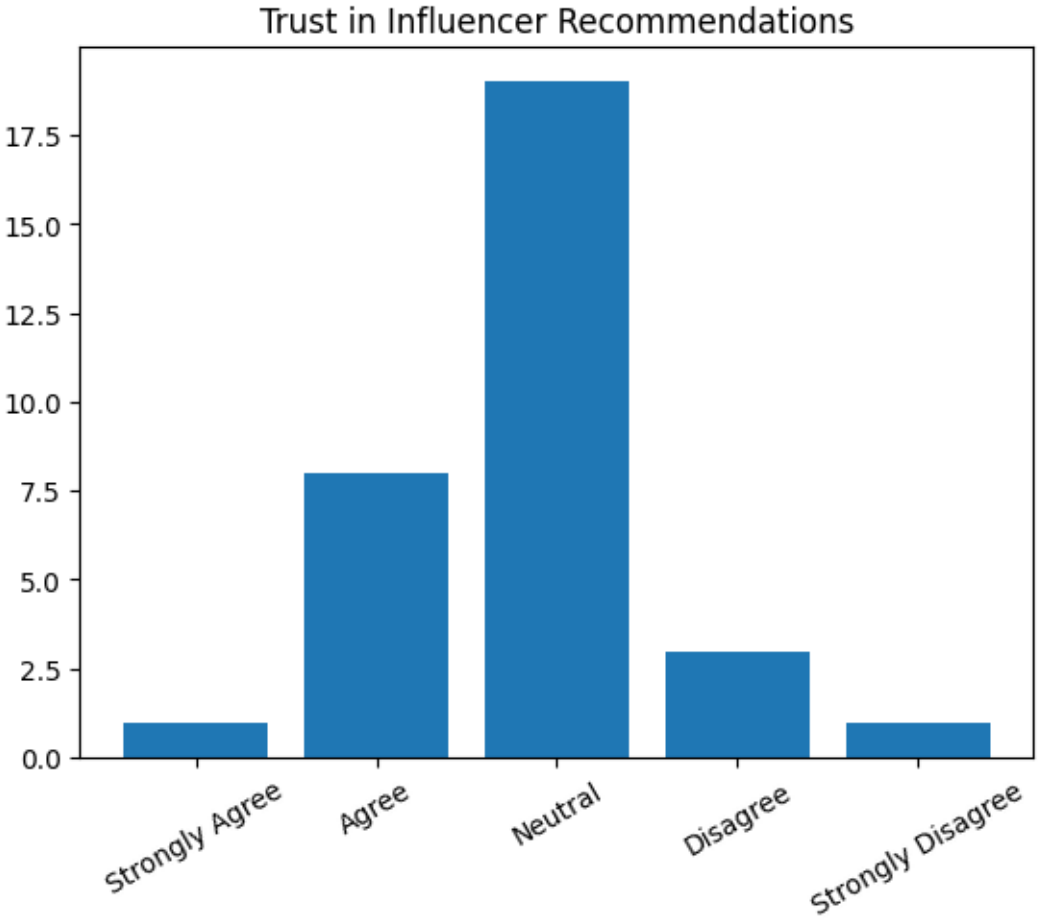
Interpretation: The vast majority of the respondents, either agree or are neutral on the topic of watching reviews of the influencers prior to making a purchase. This indicates that influencer content has a medium, yet significant impact on pre-purchase consideration.

4.4 Trust in Influencers

Table 4.5: Trust in Influencer Recommendations

Response	No. of Responses	Percentage
Strongly Agree	1	3.1%
Agree	8	25%

Neutral	19	59.4%
Disagree	3	9.4%
Strongly Disagree	1	3.1%
Total	**32**	**100%**



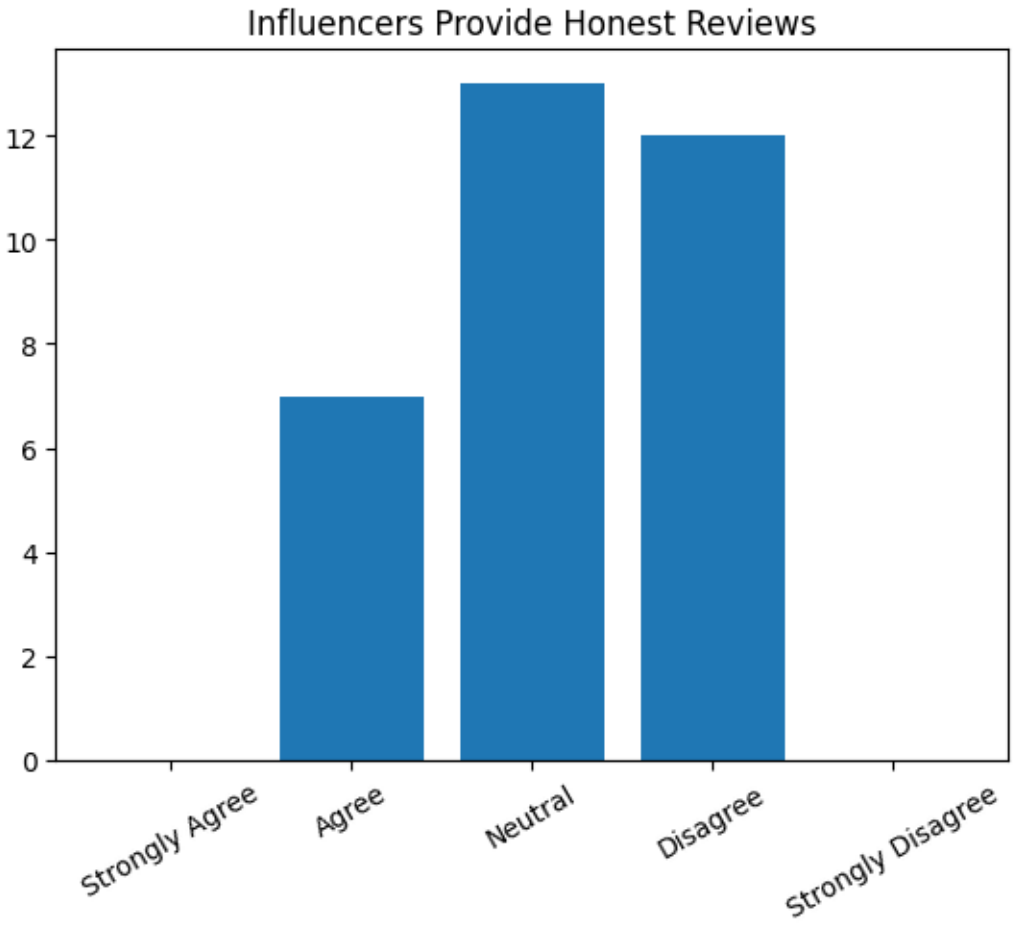
Interpretation: Most of the respondents (59.4%) are indifferent as compared to 28.1% who trust influencers. This means that there is trust but conditional, which is based on authenticity and credibility.

4.5 Perception of Honest Reviews

Table 4.6: Influencers Provide Honest Reviews

Response	No. of Responses	Percentage
Strongly Agree	0	0%

Agree	7	21.9%
Neutral	13	40.6%
Disagree	12	37.5%
Strongly Disagree	0	0%
Total	**32**	**100%**

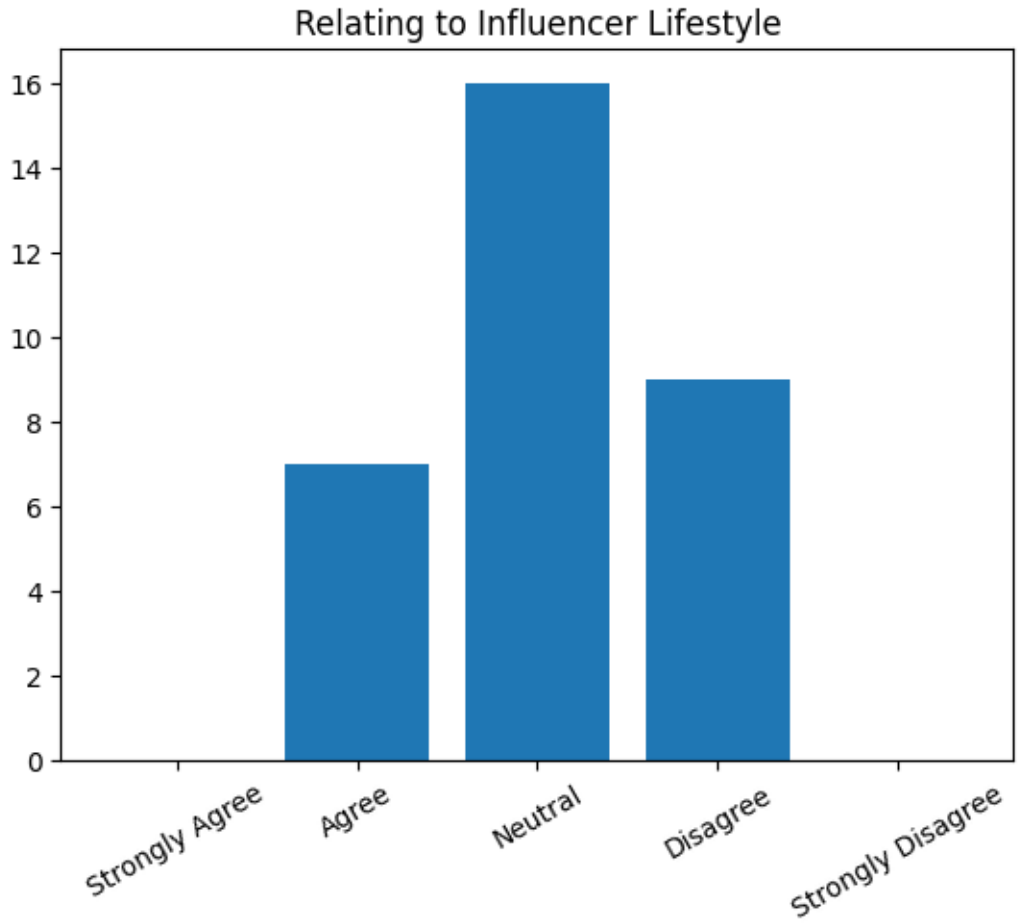


Interpretation: A big percentage of the respondents are indifferent or contradictory meaning that they are doubtful of the honesty of the influencers. This emphasizes the significance of transparency in influencer marketing.

4.6 Relatability with Influencers

Table 4.7: Relating to Influencer Lifestyle

Response	No. of Responses	Percentage
Strongly Agree	0	0%
Agree	7	21.9%
Neutral	16	50%
Disagree	9	28.1%
Strongly Disagree	0	0%

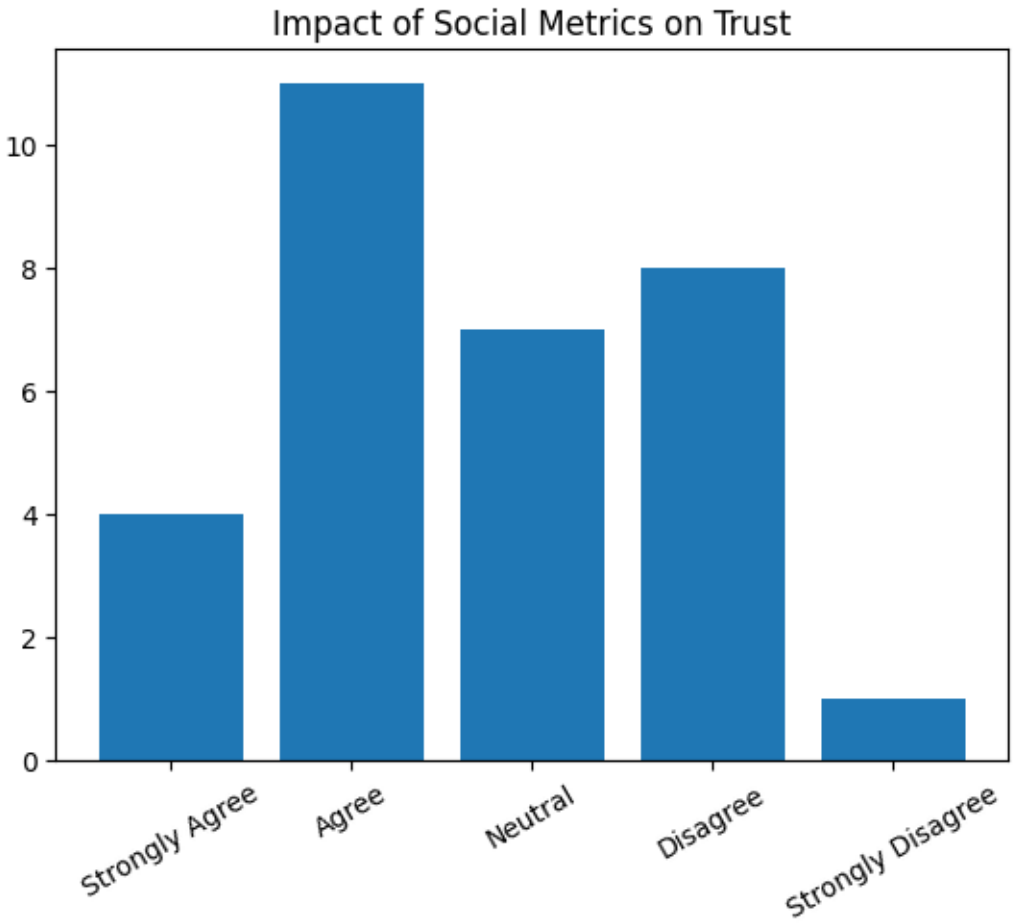


Interpretation: Fifty percent of the respondents are neutral, with some being about influencers. This implies that relatability has a mediocre role in consumer behavior.

4.7 Social Proof (Likes, Comments, Followers)

Table 4.8: Impact of Social Metrics on Trust

Response	No. of Responses	Percentage
Strongly Agree	4	12.9%
Agree	11	35.5%
Neutral	7	22.6%
Disagree	8	25.8%
Strongly Disagree	1	3.2%

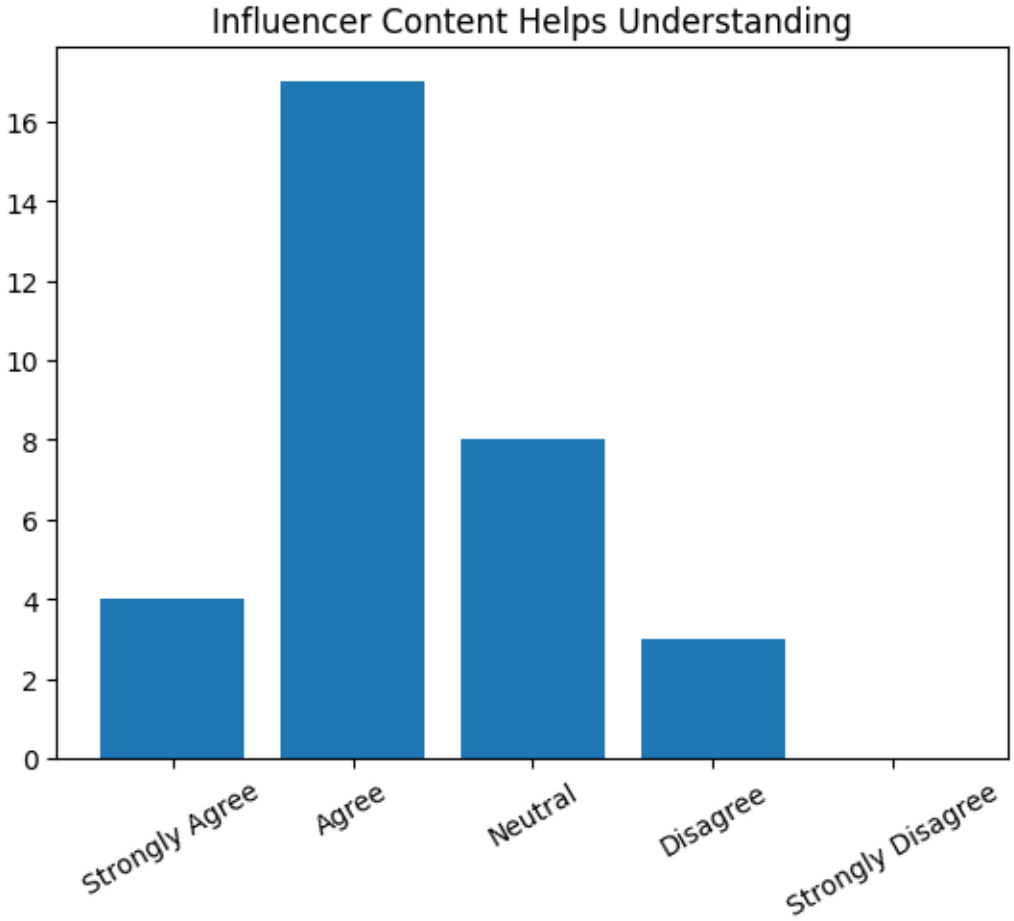


Interpretation: Almost 50% of respondents concur that trust is affected by social metrics, meaning that popularity indicators are significant in creating perceptions.

4.8 Understanding Products Through Influencer Content

Table 4.9: Influencer Content Helps Understanding

Response	No. of Responses	Percentage
Strongly Agree	4	12.5%
Agree	17	53.1%
Neutral	8	25%
Disagree	3	9.4%
Strongly Disagree	0	0%

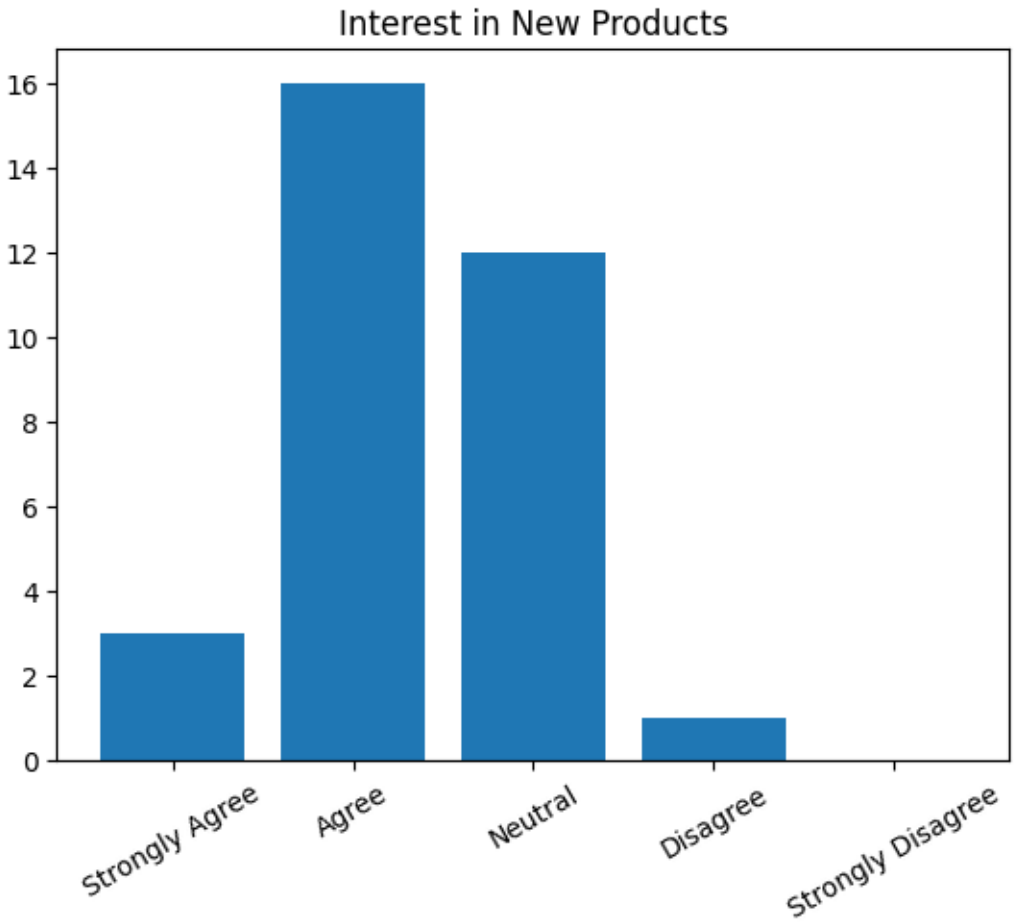


Interpretation: A majority (65.6%) agree that influencer content helps them understand products better, indicating its strong informational value.

4.9 Interest in Trying New Products

Table 4.10: Interest in New Products

Response	No. of Responses	Percentage
Strongly Agree	3	9.4%
Agree	16	50%
Neutral	12	37.5%
Disagree	1	3.1%
Strongly Disagree	0	0%

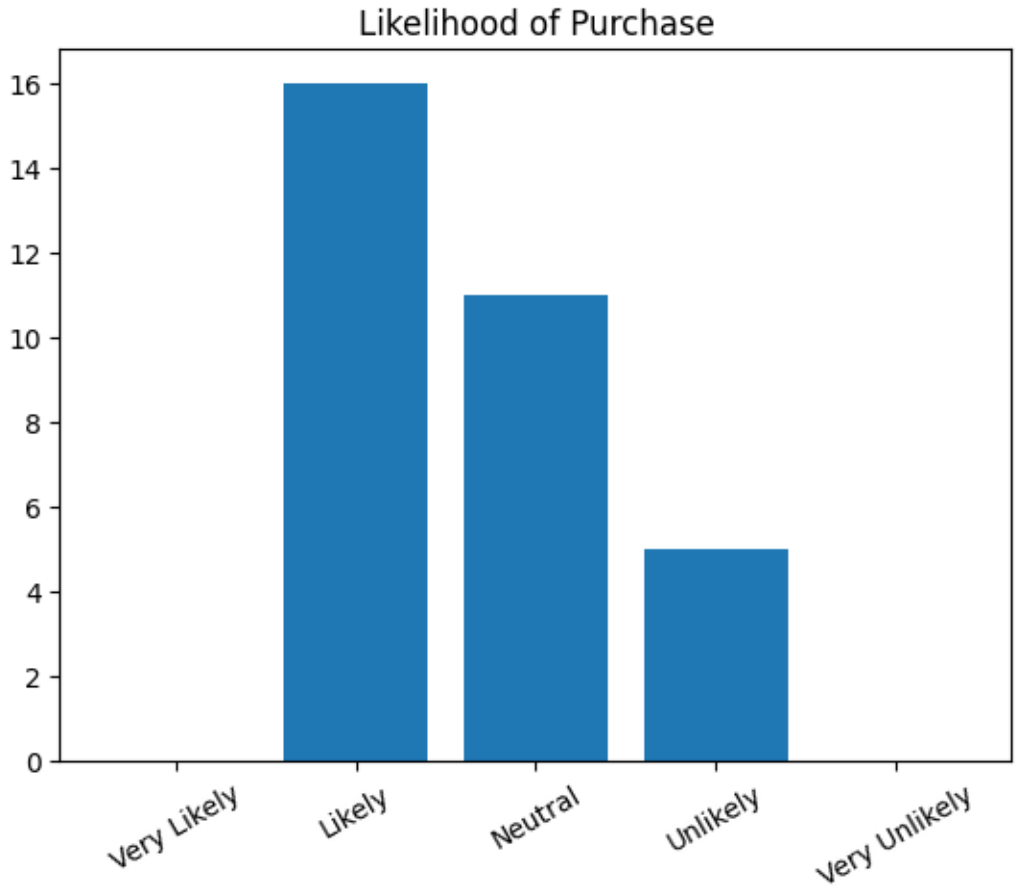


Interpretation: Half of the respondents are interested in trying new products promoted by influencers, showing strong influence on product discovery.

4.10 Purchase Intention

Table 4.11: Likelihood of Purchase

Response	No. of Responses	Percentage
Very Likely	0	0%
Likely	16	50%
Neutral	11	34.4%
Unlikely	5	15.6%
Very Unlikely	0	0%

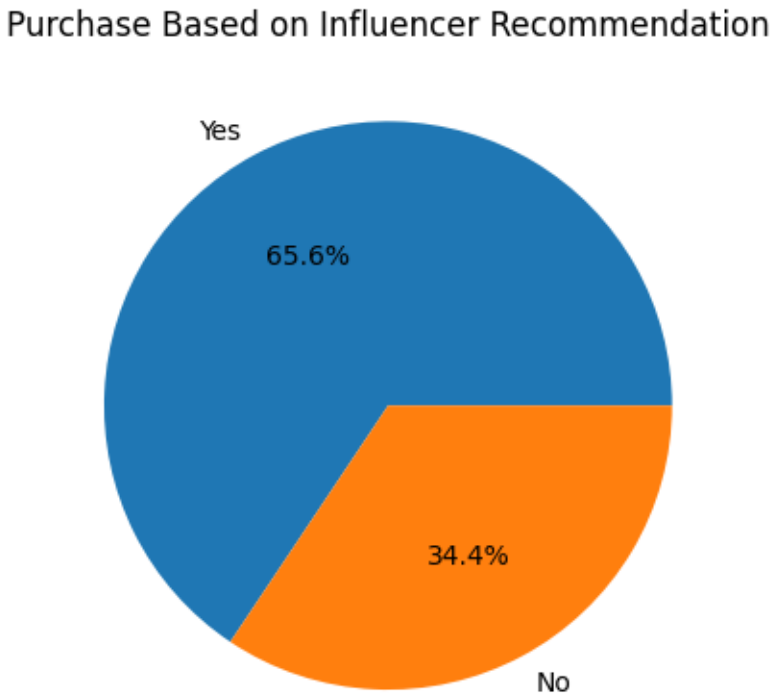


Interpretation: 50% of respondents are likely to purchase products recommended by influencers, confirming strong marketing impact.

4.11 Actual Purchase Behavior

Table 4.12: Purchase Based on Influencer Recommendation

Response	No. of Responses	Percentage
Yes	21	65.6%
No	11	34.4%



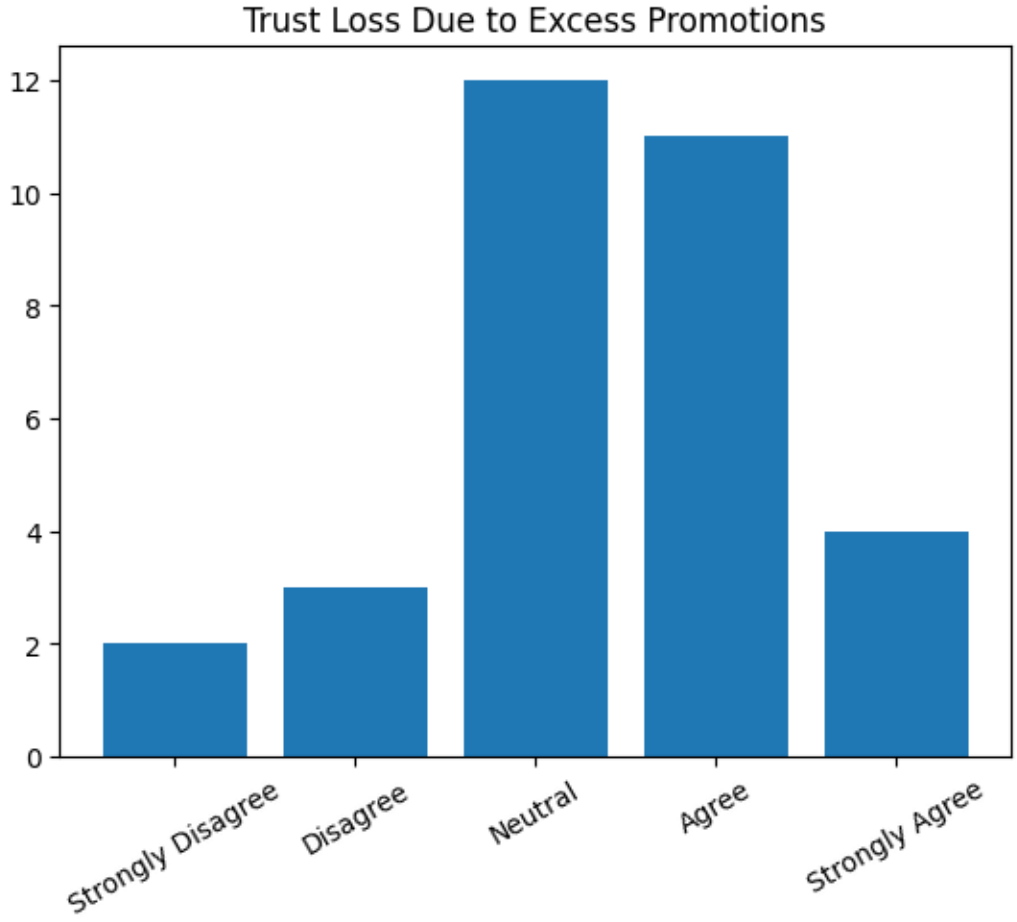
Interpretation: A majority (65.6%) have purchased products based on influencer recommendations, indicating real behavioral impact beyond intention.

4.12 Loss of Trust Due to Over-Promotion

Table 4.13: Trust Loss Due to Excess Promotions

Response	No. of Responses	Percentage
Strongly Disagree	2	6.3%
Disagree	3	9.4%
Neutral	12	37.5%

Agree	11	34.4%
Strongly Agree	4	12.5%



Interpretation: Nearly half of respondents agree that excessive promotions reduce trust, highlighting a key limitation of influencer marketing.

5. QUALITATIVE ANALYSIS (INTERVIEW)

This section presents a thematic analysis of the insights gathered through semi-structured interviews with two professionally active Instagram influencers. These interviews were designed to elicit reflective, experiential accounts of how influencers navigate the commercial and relational dimensions of their work how they build trust with their audiences, evaluate brand partnerships, create content that converts, and manage the tensions inherent in operating at the intersection of personal authenticity and commercial obligation. Six primary themes emerged through the thematic analysis process, each of which both enriches and contextualizes the quantitative findings reported in the preceding section.

5.1 Trust and Authenticity

Both influencers articulated a deeply considered understanding of trust as the foundational asset upon which their commercial value rests and as something that is built slowly, tested frequently, and can be diminished quickly by missteps in judgment or transparency. They described their relationship with their audiences as fundamentally relational rather than transactional: built through consistent, honest engagement over time rather than through any single post or campaign. One influencer described the experience of sharing a genuinely negative review of a product they had been gifted risking the brand relationship but gaining, in their account, a significant boost in audience trust and engagement as a pivotal moment in their development as a credible content creator.

5.2 Role of Reels and Video Content

Both influencers described Instagram Reels as their most commercially effective content format by a significant margin. Reels, they noted, outperform static image posts and Stories across virtually every metric including reach, engagement rate, save rate, and, crucially, the volume of product inquiry messages they receive following publication. The influencers attributed this effectiveness to several intersecting factors: the immersive nature of video, which allows product features and real-world use to be demonstrated rather than merely described; the narrative structure that Reels enable, which creates emotional engagement and memorable content experiences; and the algorithmic architecture of Instagram, which distributes Reels content significantly more broadly than other formats, including to non-followers who have not previously encountered the influencer.

5.3 Importance of Visual Appeal

Visual appeal emerged, somewhat unexpectedly, as a more significant driver of consumer behavior than either influencer had initially anticipated when they began their careers. Both described a steep learning curve in understanding how dramatically the visual quality of their content affects engagement, save rates, and the proportion of viewers who follow through to product inquiry or purchase.

5.4 Price Sensitivity

Both influencers described price as the single most common topic raised by followers in response to product content more frequent than questions about product quality, availability, or appropriateness for different use cases. Comments and direct messages requesting discount codes, asking about alternative lower-cost options, or expressing disappointment at product pricing were described as near-universal accompaniments to promotional content, particularly for products at mid-range or premium price points. The influencers have

adapted their content strategies accordingly: both now routinely incorporate affiliate discount codes or promotional partnerships into their brand collaborations, noting that the provision of even a modest discount dramatically increases both inquiry volume and reported purchase completion.

5.5 Brand Pressure and Ethical Challenges

Both influencers spoke with striking candor about the ethical tensions they navigate in their commercial partnerships. They described frequent experiences of brand partners requesting content that departed from their usual voice, insisted on claims they were not comfortable making, or required them to omit important product limitations. Both influencers had declined certain partnerships as a result of these conflicts, and both had experienced situations in which they had complied with brand requirements to an extent that made them uncomfortable in retrospect. The influencers identified the management of these tensions maintaining authentic audience relationships while fulfilling commercial obligations as one of the most genuinely difficult and emotionally taxing dimensions of their professional lives.

6. RESULTS & DISCUSSION

This section integrates the quantitative and qualitative findings of the study to develop a comprehensive, analytically grounded account of how social media influencer marketing affects the purchase intention of Gen Z consumers. The findings are discussed in relation to the research hypotheses and situated within the contemporary scholarly literature to assess their theoretical and practical significance.

6.1 Influence of Social Media Platforms

The near-total dominance of Instagram among the Gen Z consumers in this sample with 90.6% identifying it as their primary social media platform establishes a clear and strategically consequential platform priority for influencer marketing aimed at this demographic. This finding is consistent with the broader literature on Gen Z platform behavior and with industry data showing Instagram's continued strength as the primary environment for influencer content consumption and product discovery, despite the rise of TikTok in some markets (Voorveld, 2019).

6.2 Role of Trust in Influencer Marketing

The quantitative data paint a picture of trust as widespread but conditional present in meaningful proportions of the Gen Z sample but deeply qualified by perceptions of honesty and authenticity that many influencers currently fail to fully satisfy. The qualitative data from the influencer interviews richly illuminate why this is

the case, documenting the structural pressures toward inauthenticity that commercial brand partnerships exert and the deliberate, ongoing effort required to maintain audience trust in the face of those pressures.

The current study's data confirm these theoretical claims in the Indian Gen Z context and add behavioral evidence the 65.6% purchase completion rate suggesting that when trust is present and authenticity is perceived, it does convert reliably into commercial action.

6.3 Impact on Purchase Intention

The finding that 65.6% of respondents find influencer content informative and 59.4% are interested in trying new products promoted by influencers provides strong evidence for influencer marketing's dual role as both an informational and persuasive medium. Han and Chen (2023) found that informational value is an independent predictor of purchase intention in the influencer context, and the current study's data are consistent with this finding. Influencer content that helps consumers understand products better through realistic demonstration, comparative evaluation, and expert-level product knowledge provides genuine decision-support value that purely aspirational or aesthetically oriented content cannot replicate.

The qualitative data from the influencer interviews add important specificity to this finding, identifying short-form video (Reels) as the format most effective at delivering both informational and emotional value simultaneously. This convergence of quantitative and qualitative evidence establishes content format as a critical strategic variable in influencer marketing campaign design one that should receive considerably more analytical attention in both academic research and practitioner decision-making.

6.4 Importance of Content Type: Reels and Real Usage

The study surfaces a central paradox at the heart of influencer marketing as it is currently practiced: the commercial dynamics of the industry systematically generate the conditions that undermine its effectiveness. Brands incentivize high promotional volume because more posts mean more exposure while Gen Z consumers respond negatively to over-promotion, associating it with inauthenticity and commercial compromise. Social proof metrics, which brands and influencers alike use to signal popularity and credibility, are simultaneously recognized by a growing proportion of digitally literate Gen Z consumers as potentially manipulated indicators rather than reliable quality signals. These dynamics create a credibility environment that is inherently unstable and that requires active, ongoing management from all stakeholders in the influencer marketing ecosystem.

6.5 Role of Visual Appeal

The results also reveal the importance of visual aesthetics in consumer behavior. The results of both surveys and interviews show that the content that is appealing to the eye is more attractive and helps to increase the level of engagement.

This fact is supported by the literature, which implies that the visual appeal can increase the effectiveness of message and brand recognition (Jin and Phua, 2014). Aesthetic features are important to Gen Z consumers, who are very visual-oriented and can influence their purchasing choices.

6.6 Price Sensitivity and Consumer Decision-Making

Although influencer marketing can be used successfully in the development of awareness and interest, the study shows that price has a significant role in the ultimate purchase decision. Influencers claimed that their followers would often ask questions about prices, discounts and value of money prior to making a purchase.

This observation is also valid based on the survey data, with the respondents favoring those products with good value. This is in line with the theory of perceived value that Zeithaml (1988) posits, which explains that consumers determine the products in terms of perceived benefits versus the cost.

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7. HYPOTHESIS TESTING SUMMARY

Table 7.1: Summary of Hypothesis Testing

Hypothesis	Statement	Result
H1	Influencer marketing has a positive impact on consumer trust	Accepted
H2	Influencer marketing positively affects trust tendency among consumers	Accepted
H3	Influencer marketing positively influences purchase intention	Accepted

Interpretation: All three hypotheses formulated for this study are supported by the combined weight of the quantitative survey data and the qualitative interview evidence. Support for Hypothesis 1 is demonstrated by the fact that 28.1% of respondents reported being willing to trust what an influencer recommends and there is evidence from the qualitative data that authentic and transparent influencer marketing generates a high level of trust for consumers who are predisposed to engage meaningfully with content creators. Evidence of support for Hypothesis 2 is shown through the various dimensions of engagement with influencers; the conclusion being that consumers have a generally positive disposition towards influencer marketing, considering their experience with multiple influencers. Hypothesis 3 receives the most definitive result from the survey; 50%

of respondents indicated that they would buy a product recommended by an influencer and 65.6% of respondents had already purchased products as a result of an influencer's recommendation, demonstrating both attitudinally and behaviorally the positive effects of influencer marketing on a consumer's intention to purchase and their purchasing behavior.

8. CONCLUSION

The purpose of this study was to evaluate how social media influencers exert a role over Gen-Z's intent to purchase by investigating the issues of "trust" and "authenticity" regarding influencer content and their interaction factors to elicit an understanding of the effect on consumer behavior in a digital world. Both qualitative and quantitative methods were utilized to gather data from both a formalized questionnaire and interviews conducted with influencers, providing insight into how consumers behave in today's world.

The analysis provided a clear understanding of the importance of social media influencer marketing on Gen-Z's attitude formation and purchasing decisions. The quantitative phase of the study showed that Instagram is by far the most utilized social media platform for the purpose of reaching Gen-Z's content produced by social media influencers. The analysis also indicated that a large proportion of the respondents utilize social media influencer content and depend on it to provide product information. This finding shows how significant digital platforms are in terms of influencing contemporary consumer behaviors. The central theme of the research is the importance of trust in the effectiveness of influencer marketing. While many respondents have claimed to have a direct connection to influencer trust, many were neutral indicating that trust is conditional and not necessarily guaranteed. Trust can only be established through being authentic and truthful about both their experiences and their reviews. By being authentic, influencers are able to build their credibility and develop long-term relationships with their followers. By being overly promotional in their messaging or not being responsive , influencers will create doubt about their trustworthiness.

Secondly and more importantly, influencer marketing can strongly influence consumers' purchase intentions. Many participants reported that they would buy products recommended by the influencer and that they had previously purchased products based on their recommendations. This indicates that influencer marketing not only has the ability to create awareness, but also ultimately drives actual consumer behavior. Additionally, the content from the influencer is useful for consumers to gain a better understanding of the product and so they are better able to evaluate their options and come to a decision.

The last lesson of the article reveals that influencer marketing has a strong impact on the Gen Z demographic and the success of the marketing channel is determined by several interrelated factors—trust, authenticity, the

quality of the content produced (e.g., images, videos, etc.), and the perceived value of the marketing message or product being represented by the influencer. Influencers act as relationship-based marketers rather than as promotional marketers and as such, the credibility of the influencer and their audience's expectations must be considered when developing a relationship between the two parties. When brands engage with influencers to promote their products, they must ensure that the content created is compatible with the preferences of their target audience and that it does not focus on either advertising or authenticity.

To conclude, this study is related to the existing body of knowledge concerning how influencer marketing can affect Gen Z consumers by providing both empirical evidence as well as practical examples. As social media continues to develop; influencer marketing will continue to be a means of conducting digital marketing communications. Future research should explore new trends such as having micro-influencers, the use of short-form content, as well as the influence of artificial intelligence on influencer marketing practices..

9. IMPLICATIONS

For marketing professionals and brand strategists, the findings of this study offer several clear and actionable directions. First, influencer selection should prioritize authenticity, audience alignment, and engagement quality over raw follower counts the study's data consistently show that trust is the primary driver of commercial outcomes, and trust is built through perceived authenticity rather than scale. Second, campaign design should embrace and protect the influencer's authentic voice rather than seeking to control it the qualitative evidence from the influencer interviews makes clear that scripted, over-managed content is readily detected and actively resisted by Gen Z audiences. Third, video-based content formats particularly Instagram Reels should be treated as the default creative vehicle for influencer campaigns targeting Gen Z consumers, with investment in production quality proportionate to the commercial stakes of the campaign. Fourth, value propositions and pricing strategy must be integrated into influencer campaign design rather than treated as separate considerations: exclusive discount codes, promotional partnerships, and affordability signaling are effective conversion mechanisms that directly address the price sensitivity barrier identified in the data.

9.1 Implications for Marketers

The study indicates the significance of strategic influencer selection and content planning to marketers. Marketers need to invest more in influencers who are authentic, credible, and highly involved with their followers, as opposed to the number of these followers. The findings show that trust is a key factor that affects purchase intention; thus, marketers should make sure that the influencer partnerships should seem authentic and not too promotional.

Also, marketers need to pay more attention to video-based materials, especially short-form content, like reels, which are more interactive and efficient in delivering product information. Designing attractive and educative material can be an important way of boosting consumer comprehension and interest. Moreover, the marketers are advised to consider the use of value-oriented approaches like discounts, limited offers and exclusive deals, to overcome the price sensitivity among Gen Z consumers and enhance the conversion rates.

9.2 Implications for Influencers

Influencers should focus on authenticity and transparency in their content, which is highlighted in the study. It is necessary to develop and maintain trust among followers in order to become successful in the long term. Instead of being unselective about promoting products, influencers should concentrate on providing truthful reviews, life stories, and objective opinions.

The results also imply that influencers must be careful about the type of brands they team up with so as to not appear over-promoted and thus lose credibility. Interaction with followers by commenting, using direct messages, and interactive materials can also strengthen relationships and increase the impact. Also, the level of engagement and the effectiveness of the promotional activities could be enhanced through investing in the high-quality visual and video content.

9.3 Implications for Businesses

To businesses, the research indicates the increased significance of influencer marketing as an effective yet affordable promotional strategy to access Gen Z consumers. To effectively use influencer marketing, businesses will need to work with influencers that have the same brand values and are able to connect with the intended audience so that the brand's voice remains consistent and credible.

Also, the study stressed the value of businesses supporting influencers so they can produce authentic content, rather than subjecting influencers to strict promotional restrictions. The creative freedom available can allow consumers to engage with much more authentic and credible content leading to a greater volume of consumer engagement over time.

Moreover, the report recommends that businesses focus on value propositions and competitive pricing as evidence shows that price sensitivity is the leading determining factor in consumers' purchase decisions. In conclusion, businesses should develop an influencer marketing strategy that utilizes balance between credibility, authenticity, and engaging content, while also incorporating value-based offerings. When businesses, marketers, and influencers work toward the same goal of developing influencer marketing

strategies that align with retail consumers' preferences and behaviors, they are using the full capabilities of influencer marketing in a highly competitive digital environment.

10. FUTURE DIRECTIONS FOR RESEARCH

The findings of this study open a number of promising and important directions for future scholarly inquiry. As the influencer marketing industry continues to evolve at a rapid pace, the research agenda in this field must keep pace with developments that are reshaping the fundamental dynamics of digital consumer communication.

One of the most significant emerging areas warranting scholarly attention is the rise of artificial intelligence-generated influencers also known as virtual influencers or CGI influencers such as Lil Miquela and Kyra (India's first AI influencer). The ability for brands to control messaging through AI influencers opens up new possibilities for generation of trust, credibility and connection with potential buyers as well as continuous operation 24/7 across multiple platforms. However, how AI influencers impact consumers' trust, purchase intentions and brand perceptions is still largely unknown since Gen Z's habits of following and purchasing from influencers has developed in relation to their interactions with human influencer creators. Therefore, further research needs to be conducted to better understand the way in which Gen Z consumers experience AI influencer relationships in relation to important attributes of trust, credibility and purchase intention, and whether or not the process in which trusts develop in human influencers applies similarly to AI influencers.

Another area for future research is a longitudinal study examining how trust develops or erodes over time in the relationship between influencers and their followers. The current study, like many studies in this field, is limited by only looking at consumers' attitudes and behaviour at one specific point in time. The nature of trust in an influencer-follower relationship is inherently temporal. Such studies would also be better positioned to capture the impact of specific events such as a controversial brand partnership, a public controversy, or a disclosure failure on trust levels and subsequent purchase behavior.

11. LIMITATIONS

Despite the valuable insights this study provides into how marketing with influencers via social media affects the purchasing intent of Generation Z, it also has limitations which need to be addressed.

First of all, this research is based on a comparatively small sample of approximately 32-34 interview subjects. For descriptive and academic purposes, this sample size would likely be sufficient; however, it may not provide an accurate representation or generalizability of the larger population of Generation Z consumers as a

whole. The study should have used a larger sample size in order to enhance generalizability and reliability, as well as allow for more robust statistical inferences.

Secondly, Generation Z consumers are the only group that will benefit from this study; therefore, the findings cannot be generalised to any other consumer demographic such as Millennials and older customers. Different age demographics may possess different perceptions of, preferences for, as well as responses to marketing with influencers via social media than Generation Z does. As a result, the findings of this study cannot be applied to all consumer market segments without further research.

Another significant limitation of this study is that the data collected for it is reliant on the respondents themselves completing the questionnaires. A respondent's personal view, memory, or desire to please may have had an impact on how they responded to the surveys, and thereby introduce potential bias into their answer. There is a possibility that consumer behavior may not be represented by survey responses. People's opinions can change quickly; therefore it's also possible that their opinion about a product will differ from the way they respond to it in a survey due to influences outside of the time period when the data was collected.

The majority of the research that has been conducted on this topic is descriptive - meaning that researchers do not employ complex statistical techniques like correlation or regression. Although descriptive research is an effective way of understanding general trends, it does not provide a way to account for the strength and significance of relationships among variables.

The other limitation is that this study does not sample from all social media platforms - it only investigates Instagram. As a result, some participants' responses will be a reflection of the fact that they do not use other platforms.

The findings of the present study have implications for future research in social media marketing, due to the limitations outlined above.

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